

Week 14: Looking Back at the Canadian Short Story

Welcome to the final week of LSO 100: The Canadian Short Story. Across the semester, we have read stories from different periods, regions, communities, and cultural perspectives. This final week is about bringing those ideas together — not introducing new major readings, but reflecting on the stories we have studied, the literary skills we have developed, and the different ways Canadian short fiction represents identity, place, community, and change.

Question 1

Which theme appeared most often across the stories we studied?

Question 2

Which story changed your understanding of Canadian literature the most?

Question 3

How has your way of reading short fiction changed since Week 1?

The Canadian Short Story: Where We Began

At the beginning of the course, we considered what makes a short story distinctive and what it might mean to describe a story as **Canadian**. Our early readings introduced several themes that continued throughout the semester: survival, belonging, landscape, family, cultural difference, and memory. We also began learning that literary analysis requires more than identifying plot.

Key Principle

By the end of the course, the question "*What happens?*" should be only the beginning of your reading. More important questions are: **Why does the writer tell the story in this particular way?** What does the story suggest about its characters, community, or society?

Literary Skills We Developed

- **Characterization** — how writers construct identity
- **Setting** — how place shapes meaning
- **Symbolism & imagery** — the layers beneath the surface
- **Point of view** — whose perspective frames the story
- **Dialogue & structure** — how form contributes to meaning

What unites our readings is not *what* they are about, but *how* they tell their stories.

Landscape, Isolation, and Survival

Early in the semester, stories such as "**The Painted Door**" and "**To Set Our House in Order**" showed us that setting can do much more than identify where a story takes place. The physical environment can influence mood, conflict, relationships, and decision-making.

Setting as Mood

The storm in "The Painted Door" does not simply surround the characters — it intensifies problems already existing within the marriage.

Setting as Character

Throughout the semester, characters' relationships with place were complicated — some wanted to escape, others felt deeply connected.

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Setting as Conflict

Isolation is both physical and emotional. The landscape becomes a force that shapes the decisions characters make.

Place and Memory

Some characters discover that leaving a place does not mean leaving its emotional influence behind.

A setting can become **almost like another character** — shaping events, relationships, and outcomes from within the story.

Family, Childhood, and Growing Up

With stories such as **"Boys and Girls"** and **"The Boat,"** we examined how family shapes identity. Children often begin by accepting the world around them as normal — and as they grow older, they begin to recognize expectations involving gender, work, responsibility, tradition, and loyalty.



"Boys and Girls"

The narrator becomes increasingly aware that being a "girl" carries expectations she did not choose. Belonging and gendered pressure emerge slowly through daily life.



"The Boat"

Family tradition and personal ambition create a different kind of pressure — love, duty, identity, and independence do not always fit together easily.



The Adult Narrator

Many coming-of-age stories use an adult narrator looking back at childhood, allowing a gap between what the child understood and what the adult now sees.

Small Towns, Rural Life, and Community

Our readings of "**The Lamp at Noon**" and "**Spit Delaney's Island**" continued our exploration of rural and small-town communities. Community can provide belonging and familiarity, but it can also create pressure.

The Central Tension

Characters may feel attached to a place because it represents family, history, identity, or livelihood. At the same time, that same place may **limit their choices**. This tension between connection and restriction is one of the recurring concerns of Canadian literature.

Questions to Consider

- When does community provide support, and when can it become restrictive?
- Why might a character remain emotionally connected to a place they want to leave?
- How do rural settings affect conflicts differently from urban settings?

Urban Canada and Modern Life

When we moved into urban experiences through stories such as **"The Management of Grief"** and **"A North American Education,"** the course began to examine different forms of displacement and cultural complexity. Urban Canada introduces movement, diversity, institutions, migration, and encounters between people with different cultural experiences.

Private Experience and Public Systems

"The Management of Grief" shows how a deeply personal experience can become connected to public systems and social expectations — asking us to think not only about grief, but about how individuals and institutions may understand it differently.

Cultural Misunderstanding

Urban stories frequently explore what happens when institutions fail to recognize cultural difference — how bureaucratic responses can deepen rather than ease personal loss.

Belonging in the City

Urban stories represent belonging differently from rural ones — through anonymity, movement, and the complexity of living among many different communities at once.

Immigration, Multiculturalism, and Belonging

"Simple Recipes" allowed us to examine cultural identity through family, food, language, memory, and generational difference. Immigration is not simply a movement from one location to another — it can change family relationships, language, traditions, and the way individuals understand where they belong.



Food and Family Ritual

Objects and routines — food, recipes, family rituals, language — can carry memories of another place and another generation, becoming symbols of cultural identity.



Generational Difference

Traditions can also become sources of disagreement when different generations understand them differently — what one generation preserves, another may feel constrained by.



Multiple Belongings

The story asks whether someone can fully belong to more than one culture at the same time — and what it costs to try.

Indigenous Voices and Storytelling

With Thomas King's "**Borders**" and Eden Robinson's "**Traplines**," we examined Indigenous identity, family, land, colonial structures, and belonging. These stories remind us that Canadian literature contains many different histories and relationships to land.

"Borders" – Identity Beyond Categories

"Borders" challenges the idea that national identity must always fit within categories such as Canadian or American. The mother's repeated identification as Blackfoot asks readers to think about cultural identity **beyond political borders**.

Studying Indigenous voices means paying attention to whose stories are told, who has traditionally been allowed to define history, and how literature can challenge dominant narratives.

Key Questions

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Who defines identity?

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Who controls the narrative?

Language, Experimentation, and Narrative Form

As the semester continued, we became more attentive to how stories are **constructed**. Point of view, structure, memory, chronology, and narrative voice all influence how readers interpret events. Literary form is therefore not separate from content — the way a story is told contributes to what the story *means*.



Point of View

A writer can reveal information slowly, move between past and present, leave important details unstated, or allow readers to understand more than the narrator understands.



Chronology and Memory

Memory affects the reliability and meaning of a narrator's account. A story told out of sequence is making deliberate choices about what we understand and when.



Omission and Withholding

Why might an author withhold important information until later in a story? What effect does that delay create on the reader's understanding?

Consider: These choices affect meaning. The way a story is told is inseparable from what the story says.

Gender, Relationships, and Identity

Through stories such as "**Boys and Girls**" and "**The Glass Bottle Trick**," we examined how gender expectations can influence identity and relationships. Gender roles may be reinforced by family, community, marriage, culture, and everyday behaviour — some characters resist openly, others internalize gradually.

Invisible Power

These stories demonstrate that power within relationships may not always be immediately visible. Control may appear through language, expectations, domestic space, silence, or behaviour — making it harder to identify and resist.

Domestic Space as Symbol

A domestic setting can represent both belonging and confinement at the same time — the same home can feel safe and suffocating depending on whose perspective we are reading from.

Forms of Resistance

Resistance in these stories takes many forms — some visible, some quiet, some only understood in retrospect. Recognizing resistance requires close attention to detail and behaviour.

Memory, Loss, and Nostalgia

"**The Closing Down of Summer**" brought together themes of memory, work, family, place, and change. Throughout the semester, memory has helped characters understand their present lives — but memory is not simply a record.

Memory as Interpretation

People remember **selectively**. They reinterpret the past. They may idealize certain experiences while recognizing painful ones differently as adults. This makes memory especially important in literary storytelling — the act of remembering can reveal as much about the *present* as it does about the past.

Questions to Consider

- Why do characters return repeatedly to particular memories?
- Can nostalgia make the past seem better than it actually was?
- How does remembering the past influence a character's identity in the present?

Humour, Satire, and Canadian Identity

Our readings of "**One-Two-Three Little Indians**" and "**The Hockey Sweater**" demonstrated that humour can carry serious meaning. Humour can expose stereotypes, criticize institutions, reveal cultural tensions, or make difficult subjects more accessible.

Humour as Analysis

"The Hockey Sweater" uses a childhood conflict involving hockey to explore language, community, identity, and belonging. The comic surface conceals a serious cultural critique.

Satire Without Stating

Satire can criticize society without directly stating its criticism — requiring the reader to recognize what is being targeted and why the author chose humour rather than a serious tone.

Humour as Access

Sometimes humour is more effective than a serious tone precisely because it lowers defences, making an audience more receptive to ideas they might otherwise resist.

Humour should be **analyzed carefully** rather than treated as something separate from serious literature.

Future Directions and Contemporary Canada

In the later weeks of the semester, works such as "**How to Make a Friend**," "**Metalations of a Lake**," and "**Pack Ice Season**" moved our attention toward contemporary Canada and the future. These stories reflect changing conversations about identity, race, belonging, technology, environment, and community.

Identity and Race

Contemporary stories expand who is represented and whose experiences are considered central to the Canadian story.

Technology and Community

Stories explore how digital life, connectivity, and isolation intersect with questions of belonging in new ways.

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Environment

Newer works increasingly engage with ecological uncertainty, land, and the future of communities shaped by environmental change.

Expanding the Canon

New writers continue to challenge older ideas about what Canadian stories should look like and whose experiences should be represented.

What Close Reading Means Now

One of the most important skills developed throughout the course is **close reading**. Close reading means noticing details and asking why they matter.



Notice the Detail

A repeated image. An unusual description. A change in tone. An object. A silence. A contradiction. A shift in point of view. These details become **evidence for interpretation**.



Ask Why It Matters

A strong literary response does not simply say, "This story is about identity." It explains *how* the story develops that idea — with specific textual evidence.



Move from Technique to Effect

Identifying a literary technique is only the beginning. The analytical move is to explain what effect that technique creates and how it contributes to meaning.

Consider: What makes a piece of textual evidence useful? Why is it important to *explain* quotations rather than simply include them?

Bringing the Semester Together

When we look back across the fourteen weeks, several themes have appeared repeatedly. However, the stories do not give us identical answers — and that is important. Canadian literature is not one voice or one experience.

Identity & Belonging

Who are we, and where do we belong?

Memory & Change

How does the past shape the present?



Family & Community

How do relationships shape and constrain us?

Landscape & Place

How does where we live define who we are?

Immigration & Cultural Difference

What does belonging cost?

Reading these stories together allows us to see both **connections** and **differences** — which two stories from different weeks have an unexpected connection? Which theme changed the most depending on the writer or cultural context?

Reflecting on Your Growth as a Reader

Think back to the beginning of the semester. Perhaps you once read short stories mainly for plot. Now, you should be more attentive to choices involving **setting, symbolism, point of view, characterization, structure, tone, and language** — and more comfortable supporting interpretations with specific evidence.

The Goal of the Course

The goal is not to memorize every story. The goal is to become a reader who **asks better questions**. Literary analysis is a habit of mind — one that you can apply far beyond this course.

Questions to Consider

- What do you now notice in a short story that you might previously have ignored?
- Which analytical skill has improved most for you?
- What part of literary analysis do you still find most challenging?

Preparing for the Final Assignment

The Final Assignment brings together the major skills and themes of LSO 100. As you review, focus on **understanding rather than memorization**. Return to important passages. Review how literary techniques contribute to meaning. Think about connections between stories from different parts of the semester.

- Perform **close reading** — notice details and explain why they matter
- Analyze **character and identity** — using specific textual evidence
- Examine the importance of **setting** in shaping character and conflict
- Make **connections across the course** — between stories, themes, and contexts
- ↘ Reflect on your **learning** — what has changed in how you read?

Most importantly, whenever you develop an interpretation, ask yourself: **What specific evidence from the story supports this idea?**

Final Reflection: What Does "Canadian" Mean Now?

We began the course by asking what the Canadian short story might tell us about Canada. Fourteen weeks later, the answer is more complicated. Canada has appeared as landscape, family, community, memory, migration, conflict, humour, cultural identity, Indigenous land, urban experience, environmental uncertainty, and much more.

No Single Story

No single story represents the country. Instead, Canadian literature becomes meaningful through the **relationships among many different stories and voices**. The diversity of these stories is itself an answer to the question of what Canada is.

- Has your understanding of Canadian identity changed through the stories we studied?
- Which voices or experiences expanded your understanding of Canada?
- If you had to describe the Canadian short story in one sentence now, what would you say?

What Literature Can Do

These are not only questions about the course. They are questions about what literature can help us **notice, understand, and reconsider**. The skills you have developed here — close reading, evidence-based interpretation, attentiveness to form — are tools you will carry forward.

References

The following sources informed the course's critical and literary framework.

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